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H M E D A B A D , C H A N D I G A R H , D E L H I , J A I P U R , K O L K

VANCE SAYS WILL LEAVE FOR SWITZERLAND SOON, TEAM ALREADY THERE

In run-up to talks, Iran says Strait of Hormuz shut again, US denies

Iran cites Israel strikes in Lebanon, negotiators head to Switzerland

Kareem Chehayeb, Bassem Mroue & Munir Ahmed
Tyre, Beirut, Islamabad,
June 20

IRAN ON Saturday said it had closed the Strait of Hormuz because of Israel's continued attacks in Lebanon and warned

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After the Israeli airstrikes in south Lebanon, Saturday. AP

3 India-flagged oil tankers cross Strait safely: Sonowal

Vikas Pathak
New Delhi, June 20

THREE INDIAN-flagged crude oil tankers carrying "over 8.6 lakh million tonnes of cargo with 94 Indian crew members" crossed the Strait of Hormuz safely on Saturday, Union Minister of Ports, Shipping and Waterways Sarbananda Sonowal said.

In a post on X, Sonowal said

the tankers — *Desh Vaibhav*, *Desh Vibhor* and *Sanmar Herald* — had "successfully transited the Strait of Hormuz today and are en route to India". "Safe passage secured," he said.

Saying that the government was working on "highest priority to secure India's maritime interests", he added: "Our Ministry is actively coordinating with all relevant agencies to

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NEET retest today, NTA ready with more security and quick processing

All prep in 38 days: Papers, translation, printing and transportation

Abhinaya Harigovind
New Delhi, June 20

THE NATIONAL Testing Agency conducted a nationwide mock drill on Saturday to assess preparedness at centres and said it is all set to conduct a smooth and secure NEET-UG retest for 22.79 lakh candidates on Sunday.

The NTA had on May 12 announced the cancellation of the NEET-UG exam held on May 3 after allegations of a paper leak surfaced in Rajasthan. The matter is now being probed by the CBI.

"We have added personnel to reduce the waiting time for biometric authentication, so that the process is quick," National Testing Agency Director General Abhishek Singh told *The Indian Express*. The NTA has attempted to ensure a balance of adequate security

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At Renukai Career Centre, whose founder was identified by the CBI as one of those allegedly responsible for leaking and circulating the NEET-UG questions, in Maharashtra's Latur, Saturday. PALLAVI SMART

INSIDE



DENIED DELHI POLICE NOD TO CONTINUE PROTEST, DIPKE SAYS WON'T MOVE

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LEAKS STAIN NTA SCORECARD VERSUS OTHER AGENCIES

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20 new national records in three months: Behind Indian athletics' winning run

Nihal Koshie
New Delhi, June 20

THREE NEW men's 100 metres records in two days; men's 400 metres in sub-45 seconds; 8,000-point barrier crossed in decathlon; a five-decade-old marathon record down from 2 hours, 12 minutes to 2 hours, 11 minutes and 58 seconds. In just over three months, from the end of February until early June, Indian records in athletics were broken 20 times.

It's happening across age groups, too. Nineteen-year-old

•Number of times records broken

MEN	
100m	3X
Pole vault	1X
Decathlon	2X
WOMEN	
5000m, high jump, pole vault, half marathon walk, marathon walk	1X
MIXED	
4x100m relay	1X

Gurindervir Singh became the first Indian to run 100m in under 10.10s last month

*ONE DECATHLON MARK WAS WIND-AIDED; DATA FROM FEB 21 TO JUNE 13

Pooja Singh rewrote a 14-year-old women's high jump record, 31-year-old Parul Chaudhary bettered her mark in the 5,000 metres. And half-a-dozen indoor marks have also been improved.

Athletics Federation of India (AFI) spokesperson Adille Sumariwalla predicts a good show at the upcoming Commonwealth Games and the Asiad. "We have found cracks in the dam, in time the dam will break. We moved to 29 medals at the Asian Games (in 2023).

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• FRONTLINE DOCTORS IN EASTERN DRC WARN OF LIMITED TESTING, INSECURITY, FRAGILE HEALTH SYSTEMS

The outbreak is outpacing us: Inside Congo's fight against rare Ebola strain

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anchor

Rinku Ghosh
New Delhi, June 20

DR KERRY Dierberg barely pauses as she coordinates shifts of doctors, nurses and health-care workers for a 24-hour vigil at a health centre in Goma. This city, in North Kivu province in the Democratic Republic of Congo, is Ground Zero of the world's worst Ebola outbreak.



No matter what the care burden or shortage of medicines and supplies, we have to protect ourselves and healthcare workers"

DR KERRY DIERBERG,
EMERGENCY MEDICAL
COORDINATOR AT MSF

A transit hub with a population over 1 million, it has a bustling cross-border economy with Rwanda, geography which has also made it a latent spreader zone.

"It has been a month after the Ebola outbreak and it is still outpacing our response efforts. There are big gaps in surveillance, diagnosis, contact tracing and community engagement," she says, speaking from Goma to *The Indian Express*.

She rotates teams working

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Iran-US

that while negotiators were going to Switzerland for talks with the US on their interim agreement, not much was likely to happen if the fighting doesn't stop. Key mediator Pakistan said technical-level talks will begin on Sunday in Burgenstock, Switzerland, with Qatari mediators also participating.

Iran's joint military command said the strait was closed because of the US "clear breach of its commitments" by failing to

end the war. The interim deal is meant to stop fighting on all fronts.

Shortly after that, the state broadcasters said Iran's negotiating team was leaving for Switzerland, a trip originally planned for Friday. State media said the team includes parliamentary Speaker Mohammad Bagher Qalibaf, Foreign Minister Abbas Araghchi and central bank and oil officials, among others.

The US disputed Iran's announcement on the strait. "Iran does not control the Strait of Hormuz. Traffic continues to flow, and US forces are monitor-

ing the situation to ensure this remains the case," said Capt. Tim Hawkins, a spokesperson for US Central Command. The military said 55 merchant ships transited Saturday.

Iran's Foreign Ministry spokesperson Esmail Baghaei said negotiations toward a final agreement will begin only once key commitments are upheld. If they are not, "the memorandum of understanding as a whole will be jeopardized."

In Washington, Vice President JD Vance confirmed that top US negotiators Jared Kushner and Steve Witkoff were

in Switzerland and working through technical details of anticipated negotiations on Iran's nuclear program. The interim deal gives negotiators 60 days to reach a nuclear agreement, but that can be extended. Vance told *Fox News* he expects to leave for Switzerland in "the next couple of days" but acknowledged "it's always a delicate coordination dance."

As part of efforts to revive the direct talks, Pakistani Interior Minister Mohsin Naqvi met Araghchi in Tehran earlier Saturday, according to officials in Islamabad.

In Lebanon, an official with Hezbollah said Iran has informed the militant group that Tehran will not reopen the Strait of Hormuz until Israel announces publicly that it will comply with a "comprehensive ceasefire" in Lebanon and an end to military operations there.

The official also said Hezbollah will commit to a ceasefire if Israel does. There was no immediate Israeli comment.

Earlier Saturday, Israeli strikes on southern Lebanon killed at least 16 people, hours after reports emerged of a ceasefire agreement there. **AP**

Tankers

guarantee the absolute safety of Bharat's seafarers and energy lifelines."

The *Desh Vaibhav*, with 37 seafarers on board and a cargo of 2,86,572 million tonnes, is expected to reach Vadinar (Gujarat), on June 24. The *Desh Vibhor*, with 27 crew members and a cargo of 2,88,893 million tonnes, is expected at Sikka (Gujarat) the same day. The *Sanmar Herald*, with 30 seafarers on board and a cargo of 2,85,400 million tonnes, is expected to reach Paradip (Odisha) on July 1.

Athletics

Now it is only a matter of time," Sumariwalla said.

The records did not happen by accident.

The AFI's decentralisation model, introduced after the 2024 Olympics, which gave athletes freedom to train outside the national camp, played a part in unlocking their potential, Sumariwalla, also a World Athletics vice president, said.

"Our athletes are free to train wherever. If they have a good foreign coach, or Reliance (Foundation) or JSW (Sport) has a coach, it is fine. Or they can train at a state centre. Private sponsors are helping, because they are bringing the expertise and training infrastructure," Sumariwalla said.

Domestic competitions have seen a change, too. Private-sponsored teams like Reliance and JSW can participate.

The progress of the men sprinters shows the benefits of the decentralisation model. The men's 100 metres record was lowered five times in just over a year — from 10.20 seconds to 10.09 seconds. All the new marks were set by athletes training at the Reliance Foundation with foreign coaches.

"It (national record) will only go lower once that mental barrier is broken... once you go past a certain mark, others also follow, knowing that someone else has already done it," James Hillier, the Athletics Director at Reliance Foundation, said when Gurindervir Singh became the first Indian to clock a sub-10.10 seconds last month.

Even at national camps, 400-metre runners have the freedom to choose a coach. Vishal KT, the first Indian to run sub-45 seconds, owes it to foreign coach Jason Dawson, known to be a hard taskmaster. But other top quarter-milers at the camp prefer the training method of coach Raj Mohan.

"It is no longer one-size-fits-all," Manisha Malhotra, president of the JSW Sports-backed Inspire Institute of Sport (IIS), said. "Vishal is in the trajectory of a world time. Vishal bought into Jason's plan, which is working for him," Malhotra said.

Robert Bobby George, of the Anju Bobby High Performance Centre in Kengeri, Bengaluru, said trusting athletes to make a decision, combined with support from private parties, has opened new avenues. Pooja, the women's high jump national record holder trains at George's centre. "When Pooja wanted a

coach, OGQ (Olympic Gold Quest) offered that. The foreign coach is working for her. Earlier, the only option was a national camp. New generation athletes don't like being controlled. Private players complement the effort of the government and the federation," George said.

IIS's Malhotra said that private sponsors add value to the ecosystem if they bring in experts who can help with performance plans or the mental side of things. "It is not about providing a ticket to travel for the athlete. Abroad, you get a manager or an agent; here, we are trying to fill that role by finding coaches and specialists. Even if you are not at the national camp, you have a place to go and train at. There is somebody involved in your career... in good times and bad times," Malhotra said.

The coach, nutritionist, physio played a big role in Tejaswin Shankar, an NCAA champion and Asiad and CWG medalist, becoming the first Indian to cross 8,000 points in the decathlon. He is also grateful to the logistics manager who got his poles transported — without having to foot the extra baggage airline charges.

"My poles weigh about 15 kg, then two bags of 15 kg each; one for my shoes, recovery equip-

ment, and the other for clothes. I pay \$100-\$200 for excess baggage if I am abroad. When I went to the Fed Cup (in Ranchi), there was a support staff who ensured my travel from the airport to the hotel to the competition venue with my poles was sorted. You are like a cricketer whose kit is delivered to him from city to city. The sponsor paid for extra baggage. A small shift, but it makes a big impact," Shankar, a Reliance Foundation athlete, said.

Sumariwalla also credited the increase in number of domestic meets for keeping athletes sharp through the season. "There are now 40 competitions across India, about 200 days we are having events. Athletes must compete in two competitions if they want to participate in the final trials. In Europe, people compete every week. In India, people used to preserve themselves as they worried about injury. We have proved that competition is helpful. Records are breaking almost every time," Sumariwalla said.

Malhotra, however, sounded a cautionary note. "Records are good but we have a long way to go before becoming world standard. It does not matter if you get five national records and then you finish 18th in every big championship."

NEET

measures and quick processing at exam centres to avoid inconvenience to candidates.

NTA sources said the logistics of the retest will involve the Air Force, and paramilitary forces, as part of a "whole-of-government" approach towards ensuring that the exam is conducted smoothly.

The exam is being conducted at over 5,400 exam centres, a number similar to that on May 3. Security measures at centres include Aadhaar-based biometric authentication and frisking through metal detectors. State governments and district administrations are closely involved in security measures, and GPS-enabled vehicles with police escort are being used to transport exam material, as part of a set of measures that have been in place from NEET-UG 2025 onwards.

The short window between the cancellation and the retest means the NTA has been hard-pressed for time — preparations for the exam, usually held in May, begin over six months ahead of the date. This time, however, the Agency, which announced on May 15 that the exam would be conducted again on June 21, has had to prepare for the retest in 38 days, getting question papers set, translated, printed and transported, and ensuring availability of and security at exam centres all within this span of time.

The CBI inquiry into the alleged paper leak had thrown the spotlight on NTA's question paper setters and translators, with three subject experts involved in the paper setting process having been arrested so far. With the arrested experts being involved in the translation of questions — apart from English, candidates can choose to take the NEET-UG exam in one of 12 languages — the NTA is

learnt to have strengthened its protocol at this level of paper setting and translation to ensure security of questions ahead of the retest.

Ahead of the high-stakes exam scheduled to be conducted on Sunday, the Centre has also blocked access to Telegram across the country, on the grounds that the messaging platform was being used by "cheating rackets" ahead of the retest. While the app has been blocked till June 22, the platform's message editing feature will not be available till June 30.

Candidates will get an additional 15 minutes as part of the retest, which will be held from 2 pm to 5.15 pm, unlike the original exam which ended at 5 pm.

Meanwhile, after reports surfaced of a NEET candidate in Nagpur being allotted an exam centre in Abu Dhabi when admit cards were issued earlier this week, the NTA said in a statement on Saturday that an examination city correction

window was available to candidates and "NTA's web-activity records indicate that the city change in this case was made through the candidate's own registered login during the open correction window, with a consistent single-user access pattern."

"Despite the Abu Dhabi centre being chosen by the candidate, the NTA received an informal request on the evening of June 19 (just 48 hours before the exam) to change the centre to Nagpur. NTA personnel immediately initiated the change and contacted the candidate's father on 19th evening itself to help them complete the formal process," the Agency said, adding: "NTA has observed that on 3 occasions, one - the centre was changed to Abu Dhabi using candidate's credentials and twice it was previewed that the centre is Abu Dhabi. Despite that NTA has accorded to the aspirant's request and the change of centre was actioned."

Ebola

two shifts (7.30 am to 4.30 pm and 4.30 pm to 7.30 am) to ensure the facility remains operational 24 hours a day. Sleep breaks depend on the number of patients.

Dierberg, an emergency medical coordinator at Médecins Sans Frontières (MSF), is dealing with an epidemiological situation that remains unclear and is evolving rapidly. Authorities are struggling to catch up with the mushrooming epidemic of a rare Ebola strain that kills 30% to 50% of those infected and has no vaccine or cure. The outbreak has caused about 933 confirmed infections and at least 245 deaths in eastern Congo, according to the country's health ministry. But

field doctors like Dierberg say that with inadequate testing, one cannot understand if seemingly unrelated deaths could also be because of Ebola.

"One of our main concerns is that we do not yet have the full picture of the outbreak due to limited diagnostic capacity and likely under-reporting of cases. Cases may be going undetected, particularly in remote and insecure areas... The affected areas are also characterised by population movements linked to conflict, trade and mining, and poor health facilities that were already under significant strain before the outbreak. There is limited access in heavily affected areas, which is also affecting care for other diseases," she says.

So far, India has not reported any confirmed cases of the Bundibugyo Ebola virus as suspected returnees from DRC have

tested negative in Gujarat, Maharashtra and Kerala. The Health Ministry has activated rigorous surveillance protocols, including airport screening, isolation wards and testing facilities. The National Centre for Disease Control (NCDC), Indian Council of Medical Research (ICMR), and state authorities are working on swift testing, triage and contact tracing systems.

Compared with the previous outbreaks of the Bundibugyo virus, which comes from fruit bats, the number of reported cases has already exceeded those recorded during outbreaks in Uganda in 2007-2008 and in DRC in 2012.

The absence of approved vaccines and treatments, combined with limited diagnostic tools, has made early detection, isolation and patient management challenging. Dierberg ex-

plains: "Confirmation requires Bundibugyo virus-specific PCR testing, but testing capacity is limited and available in only a small number of specialized laboratories. As a result, confirming cases can take time, particularly in remote areas where access to laboratories is limited. Delays in diagnosis can affect timely isolation and make it more difficult to rapidly break chains of transmission."

There are no rapid tests which were designed for the Zaire species. Besides, these cannot identify sick people until their viral load is extremely high.

MSF's emergency programme manager Trish Newport diagnoses a bigger problem. "The number of expert medical organisations responding on the ground is still far too limited, and the level of support being provided — including our own —

falls far short of what is needed," she says.

She emphasises how the Bundibugyo virus requires stringent biosafety. "There's a shortage of specific test kits and rapid decentralised testing will take time and effort to establish. No cartridge-based assay is compatible with existing equipment, (usually an assay cartridge is compatible with a specific equipment or instrument manufactured by the same developer). New suspected cases are being reported daily, yet hundreds of samples remain untested, which means the true scale of the outbreak is still unclear," she says.

Yet DRC is not starting from zero. The country does have a strong experience in Ebola surveillance, vaccination campaigns, community engagement, laboratory capacity, and

clinical care.

Still, this grid is falling short in containing the current outbreak and surveillance systems are facing significant challenges. An effective surveillance system, says Dierberg, should include both permanent laboratory infrastructure and mobile or portable laboratories capable of reaching remote communities. "Community engagement is also essential, as trust and early reporting are critical to outbreak control. Right now, this is a weak link," says Dierberg, whose teams are also swamped by the responsibility of training healthcare workers.

This amid incidents involving attacks against them and responders. "No matter what the care burden or shortage of medicines and supplies, we have to protect ourselves and healthcare workers," she says.

Walking on footpaths is a fundamental right, says Supreme Court. Here's how Gurgaon fares

Abhimanyu Hazarika
Gurgaon, June 20

THE RIGHT to walk safely on well-demarcated footpaths is a fundamental right, the Supreme Court ruled on Friday. This right, the top court underlined, shall have priority over motorised vehicles on demarcated paths and it forms part of the right to movement guaranteed under Article 19 (1) (d) and other fundamental rights including Article 21 (right to life and liberty).

In Gurgaon, the ruling has cast fresh spotlight on concerns over the need for necessary infrastructure for citizens to walk about safely.

As per the Comprehensive Mobility Management Plan (CMMP) prepared for the Gurugram Metropolitan Development Authority (GMDA) in 2020, walking accounted for a massive 33% of all daily intra-city trips. Yet, the Millenium City's average Walkability Index, which measures safety

and security, convenience, and degree of policy support, stood at a dismal 0.68 (out of 5). Pedestrian facilities, including footpaths and safe road-crossing mechanisms, have been "grossly inadequate" and "deficient not only in quantity but also in quality," making pedestrians highly vulnerable, the CMMP highlighted.

A closer look at the city's baseline infrastructure explains the poor walkability score. Before recent interventions began, only 28% of the city's total road network was covered by footpaths, amounting to a mere 153.6 km, the CMMP noted. Across the city, footpaths span 153.6 km, primarily in the inner core area and parts of New (East) Gurgaon like MG Road and HUDA City Centre. However, it is common to see parked vehicles or vendors occupying the space.

This forces pedestrians on roads, which makes the walking experience unsafe and highly inconvenient and gives lesser



At Hamilton Court Road in Gurgaon. EXPRESS

space to vehicles to move.

Some pockets that are being developed — Badshahpur and sectors beyond the Dwarka Expressway — are said to be completely devoid of footpaths. To align the city with sustainable active transport goals, the Transport Planning Department of the School of Planning & Architecture, Delhi, conducted a walkability analysis as part of the CMMP, which identified a staggering 800 km of the city's road network as currently lacking essential pedes-

trian infrastructure.

To bridge this gap, authorities have laid out an ambitious, multi-phased roadmap. The overarching target is to develop a total city-wide footpath network of 1,083 km by 2041. This includes building new pathways along the deficient 800 km stretch, while upgrading and integrating the existing 153.6 km, effectively ensuring 100% coverage of the primary road network.

The action plan mandates that footpaths be constructed

to segregate motorised and pedestrian traffic, featuring a minimum clear width of 1.8 meters on either side of the road to comfortably accommodate two wheelchair users at the same time.

For commercial zones, this width requirement increases to at least 2.5 meters. Immediate measures also included widening existing footpaths that failed to meet the 1.8-meter standard. Even as the Supreme Court ruling has shed light on constitutional remedies against missing footpaths, turning Millennium City into a fully pedestrian-friendly city remains a work in progress.

GMDA Chief Town Planner Sanjeev Maan Saturday told *The Indian Express* that around 40% of the target in this regard has been met so far.

Underscoring the administrative commitment to fix the city's walkability crisis, Maan noted: "We will complete the target by 2041. Frequent meetings are held by the CEO where

footpaths, cycling tracks etc. are discussed and planned."

Sarika Panda Bhatt, co-founder of the Raahgiri Foundation, an NGO that works with authorities to improve sustainable urban mobility, said the SC judgment was much needed, but Gurgaon's walkability index has worsened since 2020.

"All major roads including those that had functional footpaths are dug up. The existing ones also rarely comply with Indian Roads Congress guidelines of needing to be 1.8m wide, continuous, having drops and ramps and without any instructions. All major announcements and social media posts of civic agencies are for more roads, never footpaths. There needs to be integrated planning and people-centric at grade crossings. But Gurgaon officials only focus on more roads and treat footpaths as a side project resulting in poor execution."

The judgment could have addressed safety pedestrian crossings as well, she opined.

AMID BENGAL GOVT'S 'PUSHBACK' AGAINST 'INFILTRATORS'

Tensions along border as ‘hundreds’ try to cross in from Bangladesh side

As Suvendu orders ‘detect & deport’, Dhaka refuses to accept people sent in without proper channels

Ravik Bhattacharya
Kolkata, June 20

THE INDIA-BANGLADESH border in Malda district witnessed tension Saturday after hundreds of people tried to cross over from the Bangladesh side and were thwarted by Border Security Force personnel.

Sources said that the people tried to make their way in after the Indian forces had carried out a “pushback” into Bangladesh of alleged infiltrators in the early hours. Bangladesh has refused to accept people sent in without

proper channels into its territory.

The incident took place on the Sukdevpur outpost in Baishnabnagar, which is located in an unfenced area of the border. BSF officers said that the situation was now under control.

According to sources, hundreds of people started gathering near the border on the Bangladesh side in the morning, armed with lathis, and tried to cross over into Indian territory. As BSF jawans posted at the border drove them away, crowds gathered on the Indian side too. “There was tension but we dealt



People allegedly tried to enter the Indian side from Bangladesh at the Sukdevpur border outpost in Baishnabnagar on Saturday

with the situation adequately,” a senior BSF officer said.

Since the BJP came to power, the Bengal government has announced its intention to intensify the identification of infiltrators and to push them into

Bangladesh. The attempts have been objected to by Dhaka, and resisted by the Border Guard Bangladesh.

A local villager, Chapala Mondol, said: “Hundreds of people from Bangladesh tried to

enter our side. The BSF and villagers rushed to the border and thwarted them. BSF needs to put up fencing here for our security.”

Khagen Murmu, BJP Lok Sabha MP from Maldaha Uttar, said the government was doing everything to correct the situation, repeating the allegation that the Trinamool government did not give land to the BSF for fencing the border.

“Union Home Minister Amit Shah has said that national security is our priority. The state government has started identifying infiltrators and pushing them back. However some elements in Bangladesh are trying to prevent this. This is what happened at the Sukdevpur border outpost today... But we are determined,” Murmu said.

Raju Karmakar, the BJP

MLA from Baishnabnagar, said: “Infiltrators trying to change the demographics of the country are being pushed back into Bangladesh.”

In his very first Cabinet meeting as Chief Minister, Suvendu Adhikari had announced that all the land the BSF needs for fencing the Indo-Bangla border would be handed over. As per government officials, more than 142 acres of land has already been given.

The CM also announced a “delete, detect and deport” policy to find illegal infiltrators and push them back into Bangladesh, and setting up of detention centres for this. On June 7, Adhikari claimed that 4,800 “illegal infiltrators” had been deported to Bangladesh over the past one month.

SINCE 2016, THE HIMALAYAN STATE HAS SEEN 19 FATALITIES LINKED TO THE AIR SPORT

Hollywood filmmaker’s crash puts spotlight on Himachal as paragliding destination

Saurabh Parashar
Shimla, June 20

GEORGE RICHMOND, the celebrated Hollywood cinematographer who was seriously injured during a paragliding expedition in the Deo Tibba region of Kullu district on June 8, counts among his friends former Punjab CM Amarinder Singh’s son Raninder Singh. The family pooled in all the resources, including reaching out to the IAF, to ensure Richmond reached PGIMER, Chandigarh, for timely medical help.

The 54-year-old, who has worked on blockbusters such as *Quantum of Solace* (a *James Bond* film), and *Deadpool & Wolverine*, has undergone a surgery for his spinal fracture and is said to be recovering fast. However, the incident put the spotlight on an adventure sport that has gained popularity very fast in Himachal Pradesh, with the support infrastructure struggling to keep up.

The state started emerging as a top paragliding destination globally in the past decade, the reasons being its air conditions which help the gliders upwards into the sky, and wide and open areas facing mountains providing clear spaces to fly. During the same period, there have been countless accidents, with 19 fatalities since 2016. Of these, nine were solo-paragliders, who are experienced flyers who have undergone an advanced paragliding course, and eight of them were foreign nationals.

Last year, October alone saw three accidents involving foreign nationals. While three were rescued after crash-landing following a flight from Bir-Billing, a 27-year-old Canadian solo paraglider took off from Bir-Billing and went missing with her body recovered two days later. Within 48 hours, a 47-year-old

Bir-Billing alone has seen over 2,500 foreign visitors in past 3 months. Authorities now tighten rules



Experts say there are only limited developed paragliding sites in Himachal compared to the tourists coming for the sport. EXPRESS

Austrian paraglider faced difficulties after taking off from Bir-Billing and had to be rescued.

The same month, the authorities decided to divide the Bir-Billing flying region into Green, Orange and Red Zones as per the risk factor. The proposal was finalised at a meeting attended by foreign paragliders.

Himachal has many popular paragliding sites across Kangra, Kullu, Shimla, Chamba and Lahaul & Spiti. Bir-Billing, located in the Dhauladhar mountain ranges of Kangra, at a height of around 2,400 metres, is Asia’s highest paragliding site and ranked among the world’s best.

The business boom

The credit of introducing paragliding to Bir-Billing goes widely to Neil Kinnear of England and Keith Necols of the US, who visited the site over 40 years ago. In 1984, the Hang-Gliding World Cup was held in Bir-Billing, with 43 pilots from 13 countries participating.

All aspects of paragliding now – from the registration of adventure firms offering paragliding, examining the authenticity of independent paragliders, condition of their gliders and safety equipment etc – are covered by the Himachal Pradesh Tourism Development & Registration Act, 2002.

According to the State Tourism department, there are around 45 registered paragliding operators. Of them, 21 are registered in Kangra district, which includes, besides Bir-Billing, Indrunag and Bil-Patia as paragliding sites. Kullu-Manali has registered sites at Solang, Maadi, Burua and Dabbi; Shimla district has Junga and Nangal Dev; while there are some additional registered paragliding sites at Chitkul in Kinnaur district and Pandla in Bilaspur district.

As per data with the Special Area Development Authority (SADA), Bir-Billing – now converted into a nagar panchayat – the current paragliding season

that began three months ago has seen around 2,500 foreign visitors, including for solo, long-distance and tandem flights.

Newly elected Rajya Sabha MP and the president of the Bir-Billing Paragliding Association, Anurag Sharma, says apart from topographical reasons, the affordability of travel in India compared to foreign countries is a main reason for the state’s growing popularity for paragliding.

Manali-based Roshan Lal Thakur, who has flown from paragliding sites here and abroad, says Bir-Billing and Soland Valley in Kullu are among world-class destinations. “But there are only limited developed paragliding sites in Himachal compared to the number of people coming for the sport. At times, accidents occur because of inexperienced amateur pilots, untrained flyers and inadequate infrastructure, particularly shortage of proper take-off platforms,” he says.

Sankalp Sharma, the Sub-Divisional Magistrate of Baijnath and former SADA chairman, recalls a recent incident involving an Indian-origin professional paraglider who went missing after taking off nearly half an hour before sunset without informing local authorities. “Similar cases have been reported earlier as well and in many instances domestic pilots have been found violating established safety procedures,” Sharma says.

There about two dozen marshals deputed at various paragliding sites across Himachal to supervise operations and keep a tab on unauthorised flyers. Ranvijay Vardhan, a marshal at Bir-Billing, says: “A paraglider must always carry three pieces of equipment – a parachute, a GPS tracker and a satellite walkie-talkie set. Whenever a paraglider crashes or lands in emergency conditions, they send an SOS and the oper-

ator on the ground receives an alert. The local authorities then coordinate the response.”

An office-bearer of the Bir-Billing Paragliding Association told *The Indian Express*: “Wherever private choppers are employed in rescue operations, expenses are largely borne by insurance agencies, with charges fixed, including for rescue teams that go in to get the injured paraglider and carry them to safety.”

Says Anurag Sharma: “The Department of Tourism and Aviation regularly directs paragliders not to fly deep into the mountains, and to fly in groups instead of in isolation.”

Sharma also underlines that the number of casualties in paragliding accidents in India is far less than those reported abroad.

Tightening the grip

Officials say action is being taken against operators found compromising safety standards, with around nine adventure tourism operators offering tandem paragliding flights penalised, and fined approximately Rs 50,000, in recent months.

Deputy Director, Tourism, Vinay Kumar Dhiman said: “Repeated inspection drives have led to the cancellation of licences of around six adventure firms over the last two months for violations including flying during rainfall, operating after sunset and using inadequate or sub-standard equipment.”

The state government is also strengthening pilot training. Last year, it was made mandatory for all tandem pilots to complete a paragliding safety course by September 2026.

The authorities are also strictly implementing rules regarding flying conditions. As per international norms, paragliding is prohibited during the rainy season, and operators must also factor in daily weather patterns.

2-day BRICS NSA meet from tomorrow in Delhi

Express News Service
New Delhi, June 20

INDIA WILL host the BRICS National Security Advisers’ Meeting on June 22 and 23 here, expected to be chaired by NSA Ajit Doval, the Ministry of External Affairs (MEA) announced on Saturday.

During the meeting, the NSAs and/or Heads of Delegation of the BRICS Member countries will exchange views on the theme ‘Non-traditional security challenges confronting the world today’, the MEA said.

“They will discuss the rapidly evolving nature of national security challenges, as well as the role of new technologies in emerging security threats.”

The NSAs are also expected to review the outcomes of the recently held BRICS Joint Working Groups on Counter-Terrorism, and on Security in the use of Information and Communi-

cation Technologies, it said.

Chinese Ambassador to India, Xu Feihong, wrote on X, “During the 16th Meeting of #BRICS National Security Advisers and High Representatives on National Security, the Chinese side will exchange views with other BRICS members on the current international security situation, major international and regional issues, and joint response to conventional and non-conventional security challenges, and prepare politically for the BRICS Summit to be held in September.”

According to the official confirmation available so far, Chinese Foreign Minister Wang Yi, Russian NSA Sergei Shoigu and Iranian Supreme National Security Council Deputy Secretary Nezamipour are expected to attend the BRICS NSAs’ meeting, which will set the stage for the summit of the BRICS leaders in India later in September.

AHMEDABAD AIR INDIA CRASH

Flight simulation data of US firm representing victims contrary to AAIB’s

Ritu Sharma
Ahmedabad, June 20

THE US-based legal firm that is representing nearly 130 families of those killed in the AI 171 crash in Ahmedabad last year has submitted flight simulator tests data to aviation agencies in the US and United Kingdom stating that these do not match those related to Ram Air Turbine (RAT) deployment shared in the preliminary report released by the Aircraft Accident Investigation Bureau (AAIB) of India.

The Gatwick London-bound Boeing 787 flight had crashed seconds after take-off from Ahmedabad, killing 241 of the 242 passengers, and 19 people on the ground.

As per the AAIB preliminary report, released within a month of the crash, hydraulic power was generated by RAT “4-5 seconds” after fuel system interruption onboard AI 171. However, as per Beasley Allen Law Firm, simulator tests show that RAT deploys on a Boeing 787 only “around 18 seconds” after fuel system interruption.

In the letter to the US and UK authorities, D Michael Andrews, the principal attorney of Beasley Allen, said this means that RAT

was deployed on AI 171 even before the fuel cutoff, which “is not a small mismatch but a serious technical contradiction”, and an indication that the deployment “was not caused by alleged pilot induced fuel system changes”.

RAT is Boeing 787’s back-up for hydraulic power generation, which is deployed when an electric power failure occurs.

The AAIB’s preliminary report — it is yet to come out with the final one — indicated that the switches controlling fuel to the aircraft engine moved from ‘RUN’ to ‘CUTOFF’ position within a second of each other, three seconds after liftoff. No cause for the switch movement, which led the engines to shut off, was given.

Beasley Allen shared video and preliminary data analysis from a series of flight simulator tests in a letter on June 11 to the Secretary, US Department of Transportation, Air Accidents Investigation Branch of the UK, and the US Administrator of the Federal Aviation Administration. The tests, said the firm, were conducted on a full-motion certified 787 flight simulator, by the Federation of Indian Pilots, in the presence of Andrews.

Andrews told *The Indian Ex-*

press: “The letter has been provided (to the US and UK authorities) encouraging them to consider the results of simulator testing because the RAT timeline appears to conflict with the preliminary report timeline.” The US is involved as Boeing is an American company; 50 UK nationals also died in the crash.

The letter by Beasley Allen to their authorities states: “The videos and preliminary data analysis appear to contradict key points in the timeline of VT-ANB RAT deployment and power generation contained within the Indian AAIB preliminary report. Specifically, the preliminary report states (based on VT-ANB FDR data) that fuel system interruption occurred at 08:08:42 UTC with hydraulic power produced by the RAT 4-5 seconds later. However, flight simulator testing indicates that RAT generated power is not produced until around 18 seconds following fuel system interruption... The tests indicate that the VT-ANB RAT device had to have been deployed and spinning up many seconds prior to fuel system interruption...”

FULL REPORT ON
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PARLIAMENTARY PANEL FLAGGED WHAT IT SAW AS NTA’S PROBLEMS IN ITS 2025 REPORT

As leaks stain NTA scorecard, other exam-conducting agencies fare better

Vikas Pathak & Vidheesha Kuntamalla
New Delhi, June 20

AS THE National Testing Agency (NTA) prepares to re-conduct NEET 2026 on Sunday, over a month after the cancellation of the May 12 exam following allegations of paper leaks, the conduct of competitive exams in the country has become an issue of public debate. Be it the protests of the Cockroach Janata Party or the student outreach campaign launched by Leader of Opposition Rahul Gandhi from Kota — the hub of coaching institutes — the exam conducting agency has been facing criticisms from different sections. *The Indian Express* takes a look at the conduct of major competitive exams since 2018 — the year the NTA was constituted — to compare the glitches, leaks and efficiency of different agencies in conducting the tests.

Panel Report

The Parliamentary Standing Committee on Education, Women, Children, Youth and Sports, in its report submitted to Parliament last year (371st Report, 2025), had flagged what it saw as the NTA’s problems. “It has been brought to the notice of the Committee that in the year 2024 alone, of the 14 competitive examinations conducted by the NTA, at least five faced major issues and as a result, three examinations viz. UGC-NET, CSIR-NET and NEET-PG had to be postponed, one examination viz. NEET-UG saw instances of paper leaks, and one examination i.e CUET (UG/PG) saw its results post-

Between 2021 and 2026, non-NTA agencies reported no leaks: Govt



Security personnel check arrangements ahead of NEET retest at a centre in Chikkamagaluru, Karnataka, Saturday. PTI

poned,” it noted.

“In JEE Main 2025 held in January 2025, at least 12 questions had to be withdrawn due to errors noted in the final answer key of the engineering entrance exam. The Committee observed that such instances do not inspire confidence of the examinees in the system. The Committee therefore recommends that NTA needs to quickly get their act together so that such instances... do not occur in future,” the panel said. Among the popular exams conducted by NTA are NEET for admission to medical colleges; JEE (Main) for admission to the NITs and IIITs, among other institutes; UGC-NET; CSIR-NET and CUET.

Some popular exams that are outside the purview of the

NTA are the civil services and NDA exams, both conducted by UPSC, JEE (Advanced) for admissions primarily to the IITs conducted by one among the top seven IITs each year on a rotational basis, and CAT for admissions primarily to the IIMs, conducted by individual IIMs on a rotational basis.

NTA’s record

In 2019 and 2020, the NTA conducted NEET, JEE (Main) and UGC NET with no complaints. In 2021, an FIR was registered in Jaipur after allegations of NEET paper leak circulated on social media. Arrests were made and even cash seized from an accused. The NTA denied the allegations of a paper leak and no nationwide re-

exam was ordered.

The same year, JEE (Main) came under the scanner. An FIR was registered against Affinity Education Pvt Ltd for remotely hacking exam computers from a Sonipat centre, and solving papers for candidates who paid Rs 12-15 lakh each. The CBI raided 20 locations during the investigation. For UGC-NET 2021, there were disputed allegations on social media; the NTA denied the claims and no proof of a leak was found.

In NEET 2022, there were isolated allegations of malpractices at individual centres but no confirmed leak.

In UGC NET 2022, students’ groups SFI and AISA alleged that the history paper had been leaked. The NTA denied the charge, saying the circulating paper’s format did not match that of the actual exam.

The debut year of CUET (UG) in 2022 was marked by logistical chaos and technical glitches, but there was no confirmed paper leak. The logistical issues of CUET continued the next year, but there were no major paper leak claims.

NEET-UG 2024 saw a big controversy — the question paper was photographed from the NTA’s trunk in a strong room in Hazaribagh and was sold 24 hours before the exam for Rs 30 lakh and above. The leak came to light when 67 candidates scored a perfect 720. The CBI filed five chargesheets against 45 accused. The Supreme Court refused to order a full retest; a limited retest was held for 1,563 candidates, out of whom 813 appeared.

UGC NET 2024 was can-

celled after allegations that the questions had appeared on the dark web. There were allegations against CUET PG 2024 too. In 2025, CSIR-UGC NET saw question paper leak allegations in Haryana.

In 2026, NEET (UG) was cancelled because of paper leak allegations and the retest is scheduled for June 21.

Non-NTA exams

The civil services exams for recruitment of officers to the IAS, IPS, IFS and the allied services held by the UPSC have been clean. In a reply in the Rajya Sabha on whether any question paper leaks had been reported between 2021 and 2026, the government answered in the negative. A Gujarati newspaper, however, did allege a leak in the UPSC prelims 2025, but this was denied by the agency and no FIR was registered. The JEE (Advanced) exam for admission to the IITs has also been clean over the period, with no leaks being reported. So has been CAT for admission to the IIMs.

However, long before the period under review, there was one infamous CAT leak. In 2003, one Ranjeet Don from Bihar was arrested with his associates for leaking the November 2003 CAT paper; the exam for admission to IIMs had to be held again months later.

Some of the non-NTA exams which have seen serious charges of paper leaks over these years are the BPSC common competitive examination 2022, UP police constables recruitment Exam 2024, RPSC second-grade teacher exam 2022 and the UP teacher eligibility exam paper leak of 2021.

From Kalamkari painting to Kashmiri carpet, Modi’s gifts to foreign dignitaries showcase India’s heritage

Express News Service
New Delhi, June 20

FROM KALAMKARI Mahabharata painting to Pochampally silk stole to Lakadong Turmeric to thekua — a range of Indian art, handicraft and products figured in the list of items gifted by Prime Minister Narendra Modi to foreign dignitaries during his recent visit to France and Slovakia.

The PM gifted a Kalamkari Mahabharata painting to French President Emmanuel Macron. “This hand-crafted Kalamkari painting from Andhra Pradesh showcases India’s rich artistic heritage and took nearly six months to complete,” said a source, adding that the painting was created using traditional pen-drawing techniques, and it depicts scenes from the Mahabharata. To Macron’s spouse, Modi gifted a Pochampally silk stole.



PM Narendra Modi gifted a Kalamkari Mahabharata painting to French President Emmanuel Macron; (right) the Kashmiri silk carpet he gifted to Slovakia PM Robert Fico. ANI



a handwoven textile from Telangana, made using the traditional Ikat resist-dyeing technique. Known for its intricate geometric and floral patterns, fine craftsmanship, and elegant design, it showcases India’s rich textile heritage,” said a source. The PM gifted Slovak Prime Minister Robert Fico a Kash-

miri silk carpet, which is a prestigious hand-knotted craft from Kashmir. The handwoven carpet is made from high-quality natural silk and is known for its intricate floral, paisley, vine, and medallion designs inspired by local artistic traditions and natural beauty. During his meeting with Slo-

vak President Peter Pellegrini in Bratislava, Modi gifted him a Brass Dokra Antelope set, which is a handcrafted artwork that showcases India’s ancient Dokra metal-casting tradition, practiced for centuries by tribal artisans in Chhattisgarh, Odisha, Jharkhand, and West Bengal, as per sources. “The antelope figures symbolise gentleness, agility, and harmony with nature, drawing a cultural connection to the Tatra Chamois of Slovakia, with both animals representing resilience and a deep bond with their natural environments,” said a source. The Prime Minister also gifted the handcrafted Thewa motif cufflinks, which showcase the traditional jewellery craft of Rajasthan’s Pratapgarh, featuring finely engraved gold sheets fused onto coloured glass, creating intricate and elegant designs inspired by nature and symbolism, as per an official.

The PM gifted a copy of Charak Samhita, Susruta Samhita and Thekua to Slovakia Speaker Richard Raš. While Charaka Samhita reflects India’s rich scientific and intellectual heritage, Thekua, a traditional snack from Bihar, reflects cultural tradition, festive celebration, and regional culinary. In Ayurveda, Ashwagandha is valued as a Rasayana herb that supports vitality, mental clarity, immunity, and overall well-being. It is widely studied today for its adaptogenic and health-supporting properties. Nagauri Ashwagandha also supports rural livelihoods and represents the integration of traditional Ayurvedic knowledge with modern scientific research. During the G7 Summit, the PM gifted Rajasthan’s Nagauri Ashwagandha, Meghalaya’s Lakadong Turmeric, Ramban Honey produced in the Chenab Valley and Banarsi silk stoles.

GOVERNMENT'S FLAGSHIP RURAL BROADBAND INITIATIVE IS DESIGNED TO BRIDGE DIGITAL DIVIDE

BharatNet's last mile woes: only 45% connections active

Out of 1.04 lakh public Wi-Fi hotspots installed under the scheme, just 0.7% or 766 were operational as of Sep 2025

Soumyarendra Barik & Anil Sasi

New Delhi, June 20

LESS THAN half the number of connections targeted until March 2026 by the government as part of BharatNet — its ambitious rural broadband connectivity programme — were actively using the service, with new customer additions seeing a steady decline over the last three years, data obtained by *The Indian Express* under the Right to Information (RTI) Act showed.

As of March this year, a total of 13.23 lakh (13,22,842 to be precise) fixed connections were commissioned under BharatNet, as opposed to a target of 18 lakh. However, only about 8.01 lakh connections were actively being used, the RTI data showed. According to government officials, the scheme was faltering on various parameters, with active connections, in-use Wi-Fi hotspots, last-mile connectivity, funds leakages, and confusing tariff structures.

Pegged to be the world's largest rural fiber optic network, BharatNet is the government's flagship rural broadband initiative. It is designed to bridge the digital divide by providing high-speed internet to all gram panchayats and connecting remote communities to digital public services, education,

healthcare, and entrepreneurial opportunities.

While mobile internet has seen significant penetration in the country owing to data becoming more affordable after 2016, it provides basic connectivity for daily browsing and payments. BharatNet is essential to deliver high-capacity, uninterrupted fixed-line broadband to rural areas. It could serve as the digital backbone necessary to support heavy data usage, rural e-governance, and seamless digital healthcare, while avoiding network congestion. Mobile internet is typically not well suited for such high-data use cases.

An earlier March 2025 report by the Parliamentary Standing Committee on Communication and Information Technology had said there were 12.24 lakh fixed broadband connections under BharatNet until January 2025.

Tallied with the numbers obtained by this paper through the RTI, it means that only around 98,842 new connections were added in the next 14 months until March 2026 (to take the number to 13.23 lakh), which is just a little over 7,000 new connections per month. But it is the active usage of the service where the scope of the project is faltering further, an official said.

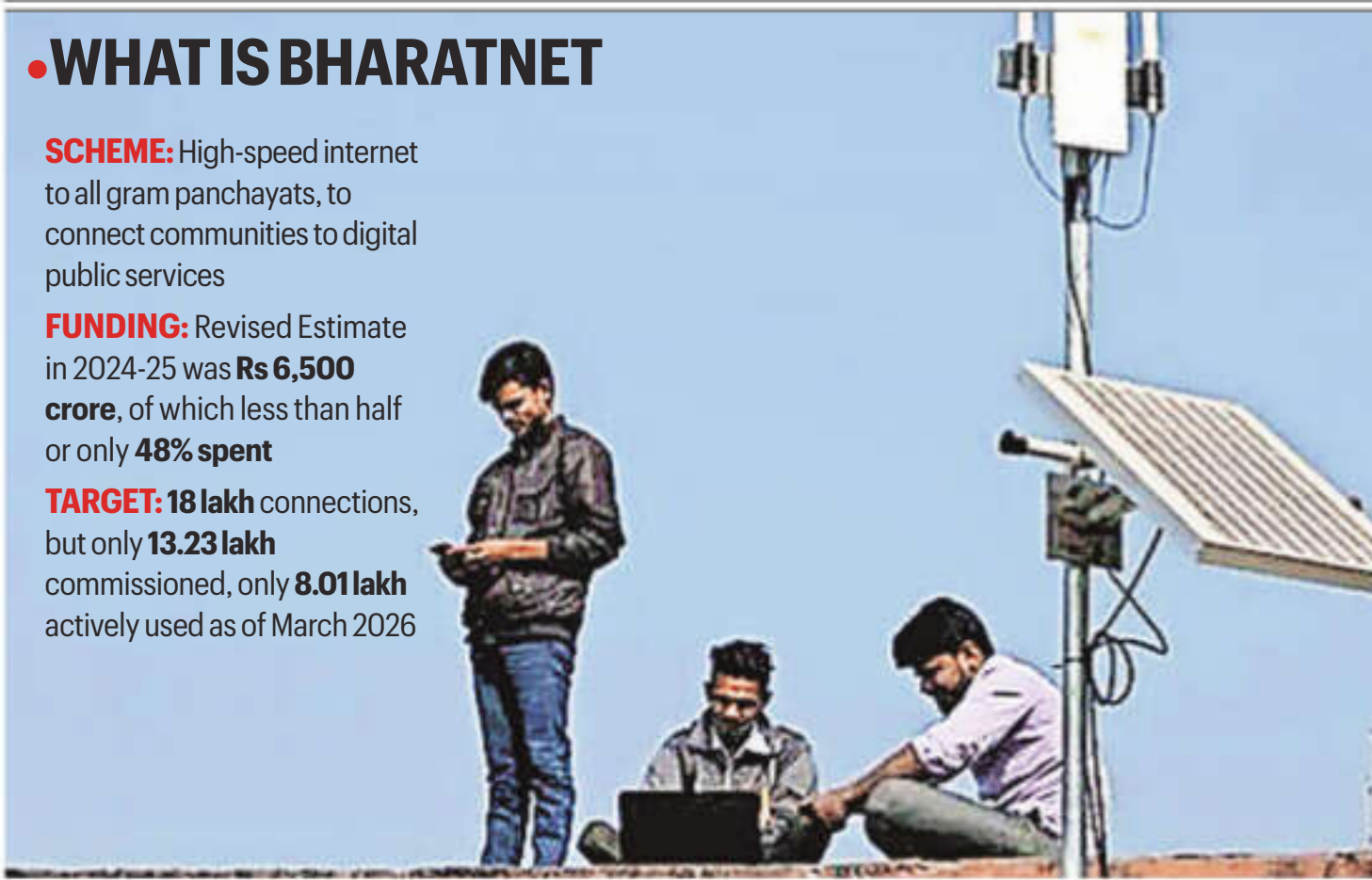
The Parliamentary panel

WHAT IS BHARATNET

SCHEME: High-speed internet to all gram panchayats, to connect communities to digital public services

FUNDING: Revised Estimate in 2024-25 was **Rs 6,500 crore**, of which less than half or only **48% spent**

TARGET: 18 lakh connections, but only **13.23 lakh** commissioned, only **8.01 lakh** actively used as of March 2026



had specifically noted that usage of the network remains suboptimal despite the availability of underlying infrastructure. It had also flagged an under-utilisation of funds, noting that the revised estimates for the scheme in 2024-25 was Rs 6,500 crore, of which only 48%, or Rs 3,145 crore were spent. Overall, the Department of Telecommunications had set a target of 18 lakh fixed broadband connections under the BharatNet scheme until March 2026. That means – at 13.23 lakh commissioned connections – only about 73% of the target was met until March in terms of commissioned, or available connections. With just 8.01 lakh active users, more than 55% of the target number of 18 lakh continued to remain inactive. Data obtained through RTI also showed there was a progressive slowdown in solidifying the user base for BharatNet over the last three

years, underscoring the lack of traction in the ambitious connectivity project.

In 2023, the number of active users connected through the BharatNet scheme stood at 4.55 lakh, which fell drastically to 2.86 lakh additions in 2024, and further still to 2.08 lakh in 2025. According to the government's latest publicly available data, 1.04 lakh public Wi-Fi hotspots were installed under the BharatNet scheme, but of this only 0.7% or 766 such hotspots were operational as of September 2025.

The Wi-Fi service is a key way to ensure last-mile delivery of the connectivity scheme. This paper had sought the latest numbers for operational Wi-Fi hotspots in the RTI application, but the question was skipped in the response; an appeal has been filed.

The Parliamentary committee had also raised concerns on the slow rollout of Wi-Fi hot-

spots in its report. It observed, "The installation of 1,04,574 Wi-Fi hotspots across gram panchayats suggests that while infrastructure exists, its actual usage remains suboptimal."

The Committee had raised concern that despite the significant infrastructure rollout, BharatNet's potential remains underutilised.

In May, Minister of State for Communications Chandra Sekhar Pemmasani said, "Learning from the shortcomings of BharatNet (phase) 1 and 2, we have fixed the issues and are executing with full accountability. Currently, only 15 lakh rural households are connected. Our target is 1.5 crore households in the first phase". The Department of Telecommunications and Bharat Sanchar Nigam Ltd (BSNL) did not respond to a request for comment until publication.

FULL REPORT ON
WWW.INDIANEXPRESS.COM

How Iran plans to regulate Hormuz via an online form

Sukalp Sharma

New Delhi, June 20

WITH THE signing of the memorandum of understanding (MoU) between the US and Iran, the Islamic Republic's newly-constituted Persian Gulf Strait Authority (PGSA) — which Tehran says will regulate maritime traffic through the Strait of Hormuz — has announced new procedures for vessels to obtain clearance to cross the maritime chokepoint that connects the Persian Gulf with the Gulf of Oman and the Arabian Sea.

And the procedure essentially involves an online form hosted on the PGSA's website.

"With reference to the signing of the Islamabad MoU and the issuance of directives by the authorities, all applicants intending to passage through the Strait of Hormuz are hereby informed that during the period specified in the MoU, vessels that submit their passing requests to the PGSA in compliance with the following points will be cleared for passage promptly.

"Official Website for submitting passage requests: PGSA.ir. Email for follow-up inquiries: info@PGSA.ir," the PGSA said in a notice posted on social media platform X.

The Strait of Hormuz usually accounts for a fifth of global oil and liquefied natural gas (LNG) flows. With the Pakistan-mediated initial pact between the US and Iran in place, there are expectations that maritime traffic through the strait will pick up and normalise over the coming weeks and months, although shipping firms are still adopting a cautious approach with the situation on the ground—and on the water—still fragile.

PGSA's notice on Hormuz transit

In its notice issued on Friday, the PGSA said that the only official channels for processing passing requests are its website and the email address mentioned. It also announced that the request to transit the Strait of Hormuz is submitted by a vessel at least 48 hours before it arrives in the area. The PGSA also said that during the initial 60-day window of the MoU, no tariffs or service fee will be collected from the ships, and will be borne by the Iranian government. Crossing the strait was completely free before the war, but Tehran now



The standard review and response time from the PGSA will be 48 hours. REUTERS

wants to charge fees for services like maritime security, navigation assistance, environmental protection, and insurance. The 14-point US-Iran MoU states that crossing the strait will be free only for 60 days, and Iran will hold talks with Oman and other Gulf littoral states "to define the future administration and maritime services in the Strait of Hormuz" in line with "international law and the sovereign rights of coastal states of the Strait of Hormuz".

"To avoid delays at the entrance or exit of the Strait of Hormuz, it is essential that passing requests, complete with all required information, are submitted at least 48 hours prior to arriving at the strait area. During the 60-day period, tariffs for security, safety, and environmental services, as well as related Iranian insurances, will not be collected from shipowners and will be borne by the government of the Islamic Republic of Iran," the PGSA said.

"Due to the presence of mine-affected areas and the necessity of ensuring safe passage and preventing collisions, coordination of the designated route and scheduled passage time for each vessel prior to moving toward the strait is mandatory; failure to comply shall be the responsibility of the vessel owner," it added.

Mandatory transit form & key terms

The PGSA website has nothing but a form for vessels to apply for permission to cross the strait. The form seeks extensive information from vessels, including regular details like

TRANSIT TERMS

NEWLY-CONSTITUTED Persian Gulf Strait Authority (PGSA) has announced new procedures for vessels to obtain clearance to cross the maritime chokepoint that connects the Persian Gulf with the Gulf of Oman and the Arabian Sea

THE PROCEDURE essentially involves an online form hosted on the PGSA's website

THE PGSA said that only official channels for processing passing requests are its website and the email address mentioned

name, flag, IMO number, type, dead weight capacity, draft, cargo type, registered owner, ship management firm, and contact details.

It also requires the cargo quantity, value, declaration of dangerous goods on board, origin and destination countries and ports, number of crew members and their nationalities, protection and indemnity (P&I) club and other insurance details, intended route of travel, intended date of crossing the strait. The form also has a link to general and specific terms and conditions for vessel passage through the strait.

The document states that the standard review and response time from the PGSA will be 48 hours, and the authority will either approve the application, mark it incomplete and put it up for further review, or explicitly deny it. If approved, the permit issued for the passage will be valid for one single transit through the strait, and will be valid for a maximum of five calendar days. If the permission expires, the permit will become null and void and a fresh application will have to be submitted. Mandatory passage conditions include a designated route for vessel transits—close to Iran's Larak island—which is specified in a map issued by the PGSA. "Any deviation from or use of alternative routes is strictly prohibited and will be treated as a violation...The owner and master assume full responsibility for any damages, fines, or accidents arising from such violations," the document states.

FULL REPORT ON
WWW.INDIANEXPRESS.COM

Mines, logistics, deep uncertainty threaten Middle East oil rebound

Shipowners remain wary of Hormuz journey until it is clear crew will be safe

Lisa Friedman & Rebecca F Elliott
Rome, June 20

OIL IS trickling out of the Persian Gulf as stranded tankers take advantage of the fragile detente between the US and Iran to cross the Strait of Hormuz.

The preliminary deal to try to end the war promised a formal reopening of the Strait, a narrow waterway on Iran's southern coast. But the agreement has brought no great flood of oil-laden ships — at least not initially.

Shipowners are eager to get out but generally remain wary of risking a journey through the strait until it is clearer that their crews will be safe. Oil producers in the area confront a similar calculus: They are ready to ramp up production but want to see evidence that a critical mass of vessels is returning to the Persian Gulf to pick up their oil. And any escalation of the regional conflict, like the violence involving Israel and Iran-backed Hezbollah militants on Friday, could

E.



As Israel continued attacks in Lebanon, Iran closed the Strait of Hormuz again Saturday. AP

deliver a blow to efforts to kick-start the flow of energy.

Still, the companies in the region that pump and distribute oil are pressing ahead with plans to expand pipelines and fuel storage. The past 16 weeks have left them keen to become less dependent on the strait.

“We are thinking seriously of having larger storage facilities all over the world,” Yasir O Al-Rumayyan, chair of Saudi Arabia's state oil giant, Saudi Aramco, said on Thursday at a conference in Rome.

This month, Sheikh Nawaf Al Sabah, CEO of state-owned oil company Kuwait Petroleum, said in Washington that the firm was in talks with Saudi Arabia and the UAE about expanding the pipeline systems in those

countries to move Kuwaiti barrels around the strait.

Kuwait has been among the hardest hit by the strait's closure because its location, sandwiched between Iraq and Saudi Arabia, leaves it no alternative route for exporting its oil.

“When you look at pipelines, they are only as safe as the export facility at the end of it,” Sheikh Nawaf said, noting that during the war, Iran launched attacks on Saudi Arabia and the UAE.

The conflict caused the largest oil supply disruption in history, and analysts said the recovery would be uneven, particularly in the Middle East. The continuing reverberations will be felt globally because the strait acts as a major artery, supplying about one-fifth of

the world's oil.

Some oil has been flowing. On Thursday, 25 ships moved through the waterway, including 14 tankers, higher than the average of recent weeks, according to Kpler, a maritime data company. Some appeared to be carrying oil out of the Gulf, and one tanker was carrying liquefied natural gas. Several empty oil tankers were returning to the Gulf, presumably en route to load oil that had accumulated in storage there. Fewer ships moved through the strait on Friday amid the bursts of regional violence.

Analysts at JPMorgan Chase said in a report on June 12 that the strait was “starting to creak open,” with an estimated 5.1 million barrels of oil flowing

through it a day, compared with 2.9 million barrels per day in May. That uptick lifted Persian Gulf oil exports to nearly 9 million barrels a day in June, JPMorgan Chase estimated, the highest level since the war began, with much of the oil leaving through ports that did not require transit through Strait.

In Saudi Arabia, the East-West pipeline, which connects the country's Gulf fields to export terminals on the Red Sea, was a “lifeline” for the kingdom's economy, Al-Rumayyan said.

“All the regional producers are preparing to increase oil production and get more oil out of the strait as soon as they can,” said Greg Brew, a senior analyst with the Eurasia Group, a consulting firm.

Many shipowners remain cautious. Jerry Kalogiratos, a CEO of Greek oil and gas shipping firms, said he was looking not only for an end to the fighting in the Persian Gulf, but also for evidence that his vessels would be able to navigate the strait safely and secure insurance to do so.

Ensuring the waterway is safe from mines could take weeks, experts said. And shipping companies will need to secure war risk coverage from maritime insurers.

Also a hurdle: getting tankers back in through the strait to help drain regional storage facilities, which companies have filled to the brim. NYT

